LIGHTING

The Lighting Plot and the Cue Sheet

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The paperwork that turns a design into a repeatable performance: the rig plan, the channel schedule, the focus notes and the cue sheet the operator actually runs.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- rig plan
- channel schedule
- focus
- cue sheet
- the paper tech

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Why paperwork is the design

A lighting design exists twice: once in the designer's head and once on paper. Only the paper survives to the performance. If the plot cannot be read by a crew that has never met you, the design will be replaced in the first technical rehearsal by whatever the operator can remember.

The rig plan

Draw the stage to scale with the bars, the positions and the auditorium, and place every lantern on it with a number. Use the venue's own position names. Each lantern gets a symbol showing its type, its channel and the gel or colour it carries. The plan should let a rigger hang the show without asking a question.

Beside the plan, list every instrument: number, type, wattage, position, channel, colour, gobo, and what it is for ("DSR special", "blue back wash"). This is the schedule the crew works from, and the document you hand to the venue.

Focus

Focus is done with the stage marked: tape the acting areas, put a stand-in on each mark, and work through the plot in order. Write down what each lantern was focused on, because in the dress rehearsal someone will ask. Focus notes are also the record for the next venue.

The cue sheet

A cue sheet has a number, a trigger and a description. The trigger is what the operator hears or sees: "on the line 'I am not your wife'", "on the blackout at the end of act one". The description is what changes: "cue 12: DS special out, blue back to 40 per cent over four".

Keep cues to tens or fives where you can: renumbering in the technical rehearsal is easier and the operator is less likely to jump one. Standby every cue over the talkback, and write the standby into the sheet for the cues that come without warning.

The paper tech is where the director, the stage manager and the designer agree the cue list before anyone touches a console. It saves hours in the theatre and it is the single most useful meeting in the production.

The console, the cue stack and the show file

Modern consoles store cues as a stack, and the operator runs the stack rather than the channels. Build the show in the console in the order it will be performed, label every cue with the page and the trigger, and save two copies of the show file: one on the console and one on a USB stick in the stage manager's folder. A console that loses its memory an hour before the show has ended productions.

Keep a paper backup: the cue sheet, the channel schedule and a photograph of the console screen at the top of the show. If the console fails, you can at least run the show on the house lights and the practicals and tell the audience what is happening.

Rehearse the cues before the technical rehearsal. A "dry tech" - the stage manager calling the cues with no actors, the operator pressing go - takes an hour and finds the cue that was written for a page that no longer exists. Directors who skip it spend the first dress rehearsal discovering the same thing slowly, in costume, with an

audience of thirty waiting.

Cue timing

A cue has a duration as well as a level. A four-second fade reads as a change of mood; a twenty-second fade reads as a change of time; a snap reads as an event. Write the duration on the sheet, and rehearse it with a stopwatch, because operators count differently and the difference is visible.

Cue the cue, not the line. If the cue is written for "on her entrance", the operator watches the door; if it is written for a line, the operator listens for the line and the entrance is late. Choose the trigger that is easiest to see or hear, and write it in the words the operator will actually hear.

Exercises

1. Draw a rig plan for a 6 m by 4 m stage with eight lanterns and a 12-channel desk. Include the schedule.
2. Write a cue sheet of ten cues for a five-minute scene, with triggers taken from the script.
3. Run a paper tech with a stage manager: read the scene aloud and call every cue at its trigger.

Where to read more

Steven Louis Shelley, A Practical Guide to Stage Lighting (2013)

Francis Reid, The Stage Lighting Handbook

Richard Pilbrow, Stage Lighting Design (1997)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.